Flexible Working Practices

Unit 1 · 1.3.4.1 Approaches to staffing

Flexible working practices vary the **time, location or pattern** of work to balance employee needs with the firm's demand.

Main forms

- **Part-time & full-time** — part-time gives guaranteed but fewer hours; useful for covering peaks.
- **Temporary / fixed-term** — cover short-term needs (e.g. a seasonal chef).
- **Flexible hours (flexitime)** — staff choose start/finish times (e.g. Google, around core meetings).
- **Home / remote working** — cuts office and commuting costs but can weaken collaboration (Yahoo! banned it).
- **Multi-skilling** — training staff in several roles (e.g. Carrefour cashiers helping in the bakery).
- **Outsourcing** — contracting work to other firms (e.g. Nike manufacturing in Vietnam, Indonesia, China).

Evaluation

Flexibility cuts fixed labour costs and matches staffing to demand, but can reduce loyalty, commitment and control over quality if overused. Worked examples: M&S (part-time, job-share), PwC Flexible Talent Network (2,000+ applicants), Sports Direct (zero-hour vs part-time).